
c. 1637–1707, DANISH-GERMAN

The date and exact place of Buxtehude's birth are uncertain. Reflecting the complex, shifting political geography of the time, he is sometimes described as Danish and sometimes as German. His early career was spent in what is now Denmark, and from 1668 until his death he held the highly prestigious post of organist at the Marienkirche (St. Mary's Church) in Lübeck (now in Germany), a huge and wealthy church with an outstanding musical tradition. In effect, he was music director for the whole city. He was acclaimed as one of the greatest organists of his time and his compositions for the instrument form the most important body of such work before those of J.S. Bach. Buxtehude also wrote a good deal of sacred (and some secular) vocal music and instrumental music for various combinations of instruments, mainly strings.

KEY WORKS: *Membra Jesu nostri* (The Limbs of our Jesus [oratorio]), 1680; *Seven Trio Sonatas* (for violin, viola da gamba, and harpsichord), 1696; *Passacaglia in D minor*, c. 1690–1700

Marc-Antoine Charpentier